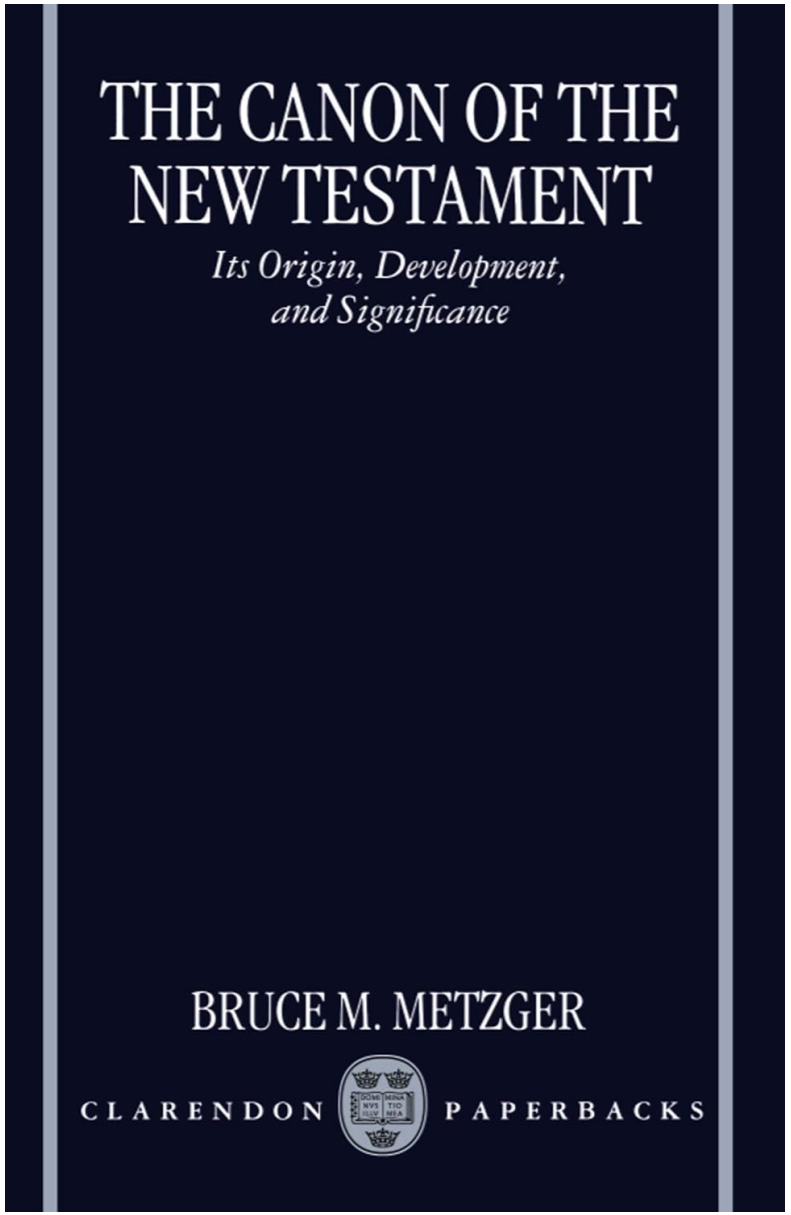
Class 1:
Introduction to the Canon of the NT

Based on B. Metzger, *The Canon of the New Testament: Its Origin, Development, and Significance,* Oxford (1987)

Sources

- Primarily: Bruce Metzger, *The Canon of the New Testament: Its Origin, Development, and Significance* (Oxford: 1987)
- This book is considered the standard work on the NT canon
- Other sources used as well (such as my work on 1 and 2 Peter)
  - Unless otherwise stated, assume all material is from Metzger



Download Slides

- https://joshuahaub.com/notes/nt-canon/



What is “the Canon”?

- “Much of the present confusion over the problem of canon turns on the failure to reach an agreement regarding terminology” (Brevard Childs as quoted by M. Kruger, *Canon Revisited*, p. 27)
- Metzger: “Still more basic are the questions of whether the canon is a collection of authoritative books or an authoritative collection of books—and in either case whether the collection can be held to reflect the divine intention within the history of salvation” (Metzger, p. 1)
- Definition for this study: **the canon is “a closed list of authoritative, sacred texts”** (undergraduate professor, 2026)

What is “the Canon”?

the canon is “a closed list of authoritative, sacred texts”
(undergraduate professor, 2026)

#1: “Canon”

- The term “canon” comes from the Greek word meaning, “rule” or “standard” (3x in 2 Cor 10:13-16; 1x in Gal 6:16)
- It is believed by some that Athanasius (4th century) was the first person to use the term in reference to a “canon of sacred Scripture” (matches our OT and NT)

Athanasius (367 AD)

… 1. They have fabricated books which they call books of tables[5], in which they shew stars, to which they give the names of Saints. And therein of a truth they have inflicted on themselves a double reproach: those who have written such books, because they have perfected themselves in a lying and contemptible science; and as to the ignorant and simple, they have led them astray by evil thoughts concerning the right faith established in all truth and upright in the presence of God.

… 2. But since we have made mention of heretics as dead, but of ourselves as possessing the Divine Scriptures for salvation; and since I fear lest, as Paul wrote to the Corinthians[7], some few of the simple should be beguiled from their simplicity and purity, by the subtilty of certain men, and should henceforth read other books—those called apocryphal—led astray by the

… 2. But since we have made mention of heretics as dead, but of ourselves as possessing the Divine Scriptures for salvation; and since I fear lest, as Paul wrote to the Corinthians[7], some few of the simple should be beguiled from their simplicity and purity, by the subtilty of certain men, and should henceforth read other books—those called apocryphal—led astray by the similarity of their names with the true books; I beseech you to bear patiently, if I also write, by way of remembrance, of matters with which you are acquainted, influenced by the need and advantage of the Church.

3. In proceeding to make mention of these things, I shall adopt, to commend my undertaking, the pattern of Luke the Evangelist, saying on my own account: 'Forasmuch as some have taken in hand,' to reduce into order for themselves the books termed apocryphal, and to mix them up with the divinely inspired Scripture, concerning which we have been fully persuaded, as they who from the beginning were eye-witnesses and ministers of the Word, delivered to the fathers; it seemed p 552 good to me also, having been urged thereto by true brethren, and having learned from the beginning, to set before you the books

included in the Canon, and handed down, and accredited as Divine; to the end that any one who has fallen into error may condemn those who have led him astray; and that he who has continued stedfast in purity may again rejoice, having these things brought to his remembrance.

4. There are, then, **of the Old Testament, twenty-two books in number**; for, as I have heard, it is handed down that this is the number of the letters among the Hebrews; their respective order and names being as follows. The first is Genesis, then Exodus, next Leviticus, after that Numbers, and then Deuteronomy. Following these there is Joshua, the son of Nun, then Judges, then Ruth. And again, after these four books of Kings, the first and second being reckoned as one book, and so likewise the third and fourth as one book. And again, the first and second of the Chronicles are reckoned as one book. Again Ezra, the first and second are similarly one book. After these there is the book of Psalms, then the Proverbs, next Ecclesiastes, and the Song of Songs. Job follows, then the Prophets, the twelve being reckoned as one book. Then Isaiah, one book, then Jeremiah with Baruch, Lamentations, and[2] the epistle,

Job follows, then the Prophets, the twelve being reckoned as one book. Then Isaiah, one book, then Jeremiah with Baruch, Lamentations, and[2] the epistle, one book; afterwards, Ezekiel and Daniel, each one book. Thus far constitutes the Old Testament.

5. Again it is not tedious to speak of the [books] of the New Testament. These are, the four Gospels, according to **Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John**. Afterwards, the **Acts of the Apostles** and Epistles (called Catholic), seven, viz. **of James, one; of Peter, two; of John, three; after these, one of Jude**. In addition, there are **fourteen Epistles of Paul**, written in this order. The first, to the Romans; then two to the Corinthians; after these, to the Galatians; next, to the Ephesians; then to the Philippians; then to the Colossians; after these, two to the Thessalonians, and that to the Hebrews; and again, two to Timothy; one to Titus; and lastly, that to Philemon. And besides, **the Revelation of John**.

6. These are fountains of salvation, that they who thirst may be satisfied with the living words they contain. In these alone is proclaimed the doctrine of godliness. Let no man add to these, neither let him take ought from these. For

godliness. Let no man add to these, neither let him take ought from these. For concerning these the Lord put to shame the Sadducees, and said, ‘Ye do err, not knowing the Scriptures.’ And He reproved the Jews, saying, ‘Search the Scriptures, for these are they that testify of Me.’

7. But for greater exactness I add this also, writing of necessity; that there are other books besides these not indeed included in the Canon, but appointed by the Fathers to be read by those who newly join us, and who wish for instruction in the word of godliness. The Wisdom of Solomon, and the Wisdom of Sirach, and Esther, and Judith, and Tobit, and that which is called the Teaching of the Apostles, and the Shepherd. But the former, my brethren, are included in the Canon, the latter being [merely] read; nor is there in any place a mention of apocryphal writings. But they are an invention of heretics, who write them when they choose, bestowing upon them their approbation, and assigning to them a date, that so, using them as ancient writings, they may find occasion to lead astray the simple.

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Athanasius of Alexandria, "Festal Letters," in St. Athanasius: Select Works and Letters, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace, trans. Henry Burgess and Jessie Smith Payne, vol. 4 of A Select Library of the Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers of the Christian Church, Second Series (New York: Christian Literature Company, 1892), 551–552.

For free: https://www.bible-researcher.com/athanasius.html

What is “the Canon”?

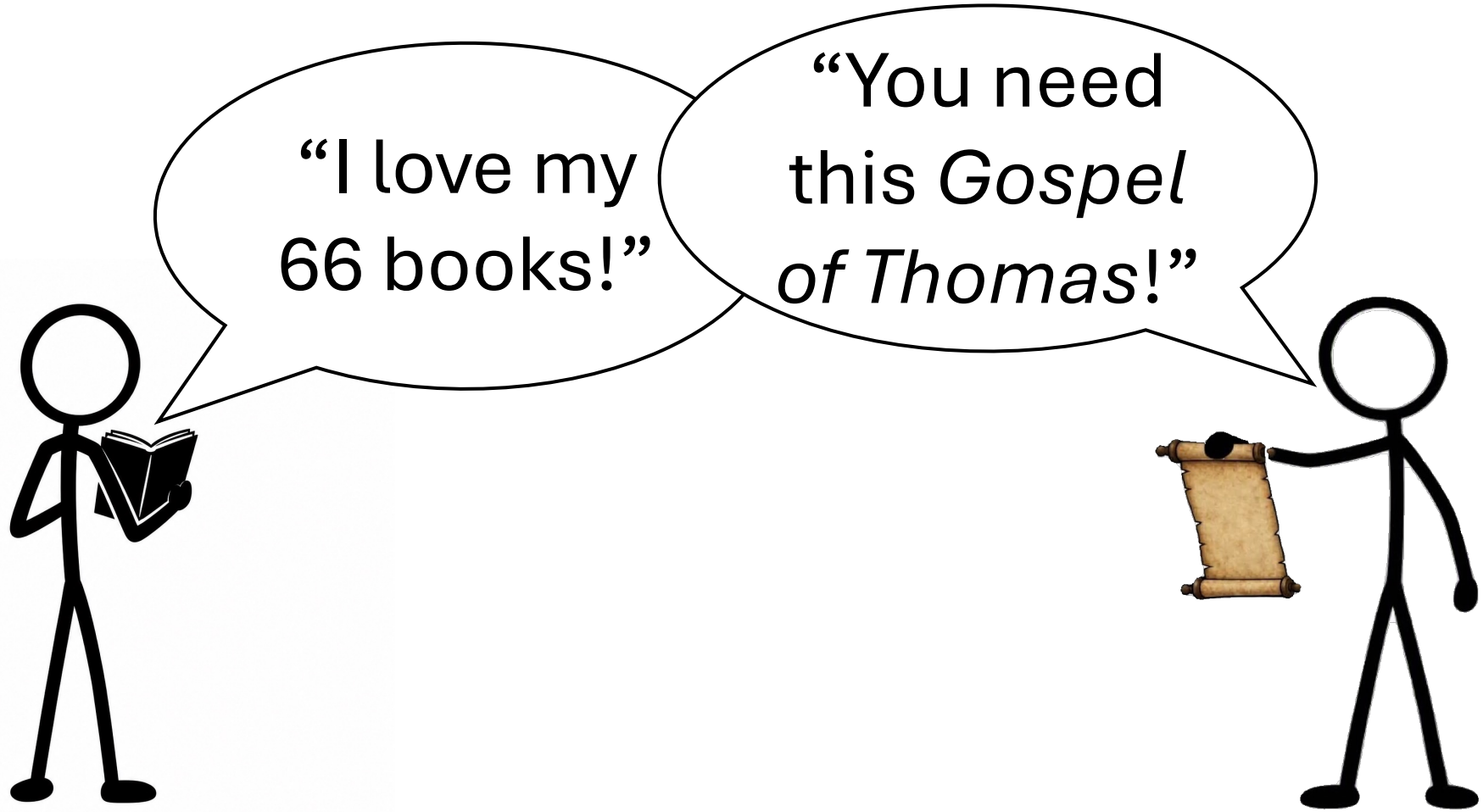
the canon is “a closed list of authoritative, sacred texts”
(undergraduate professor, 2026)

#2: “Closed”

- “Closed” means: There are no new books being added

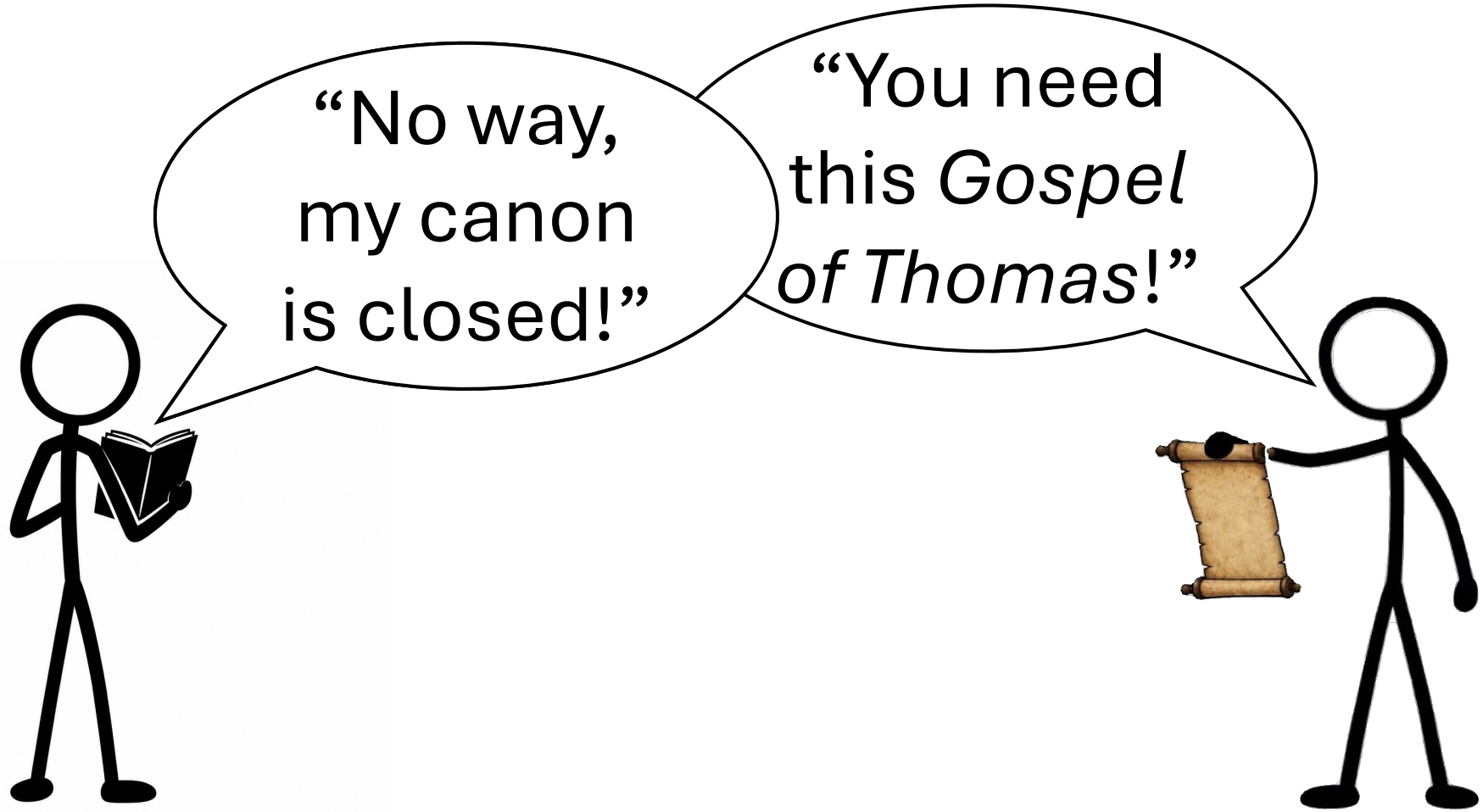
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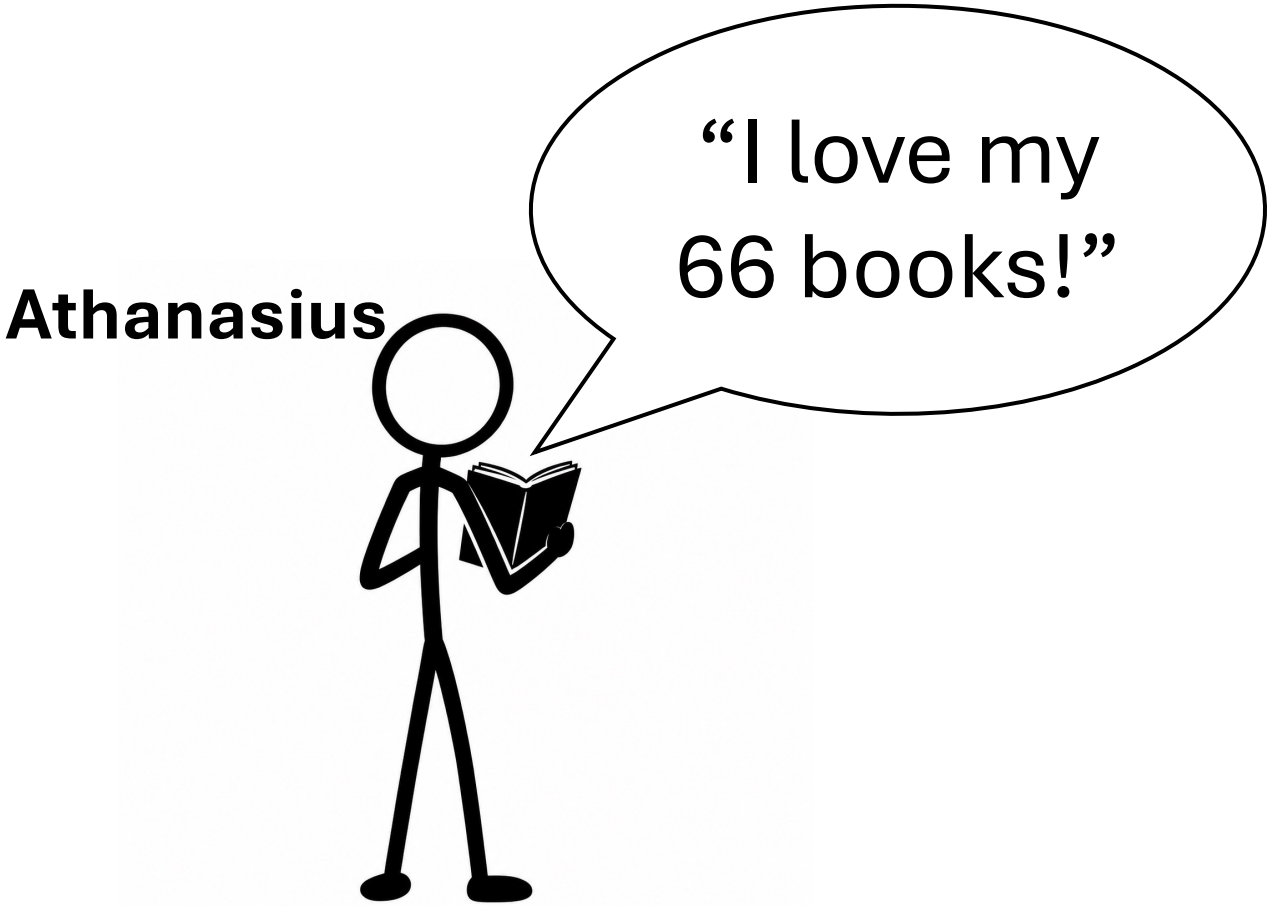
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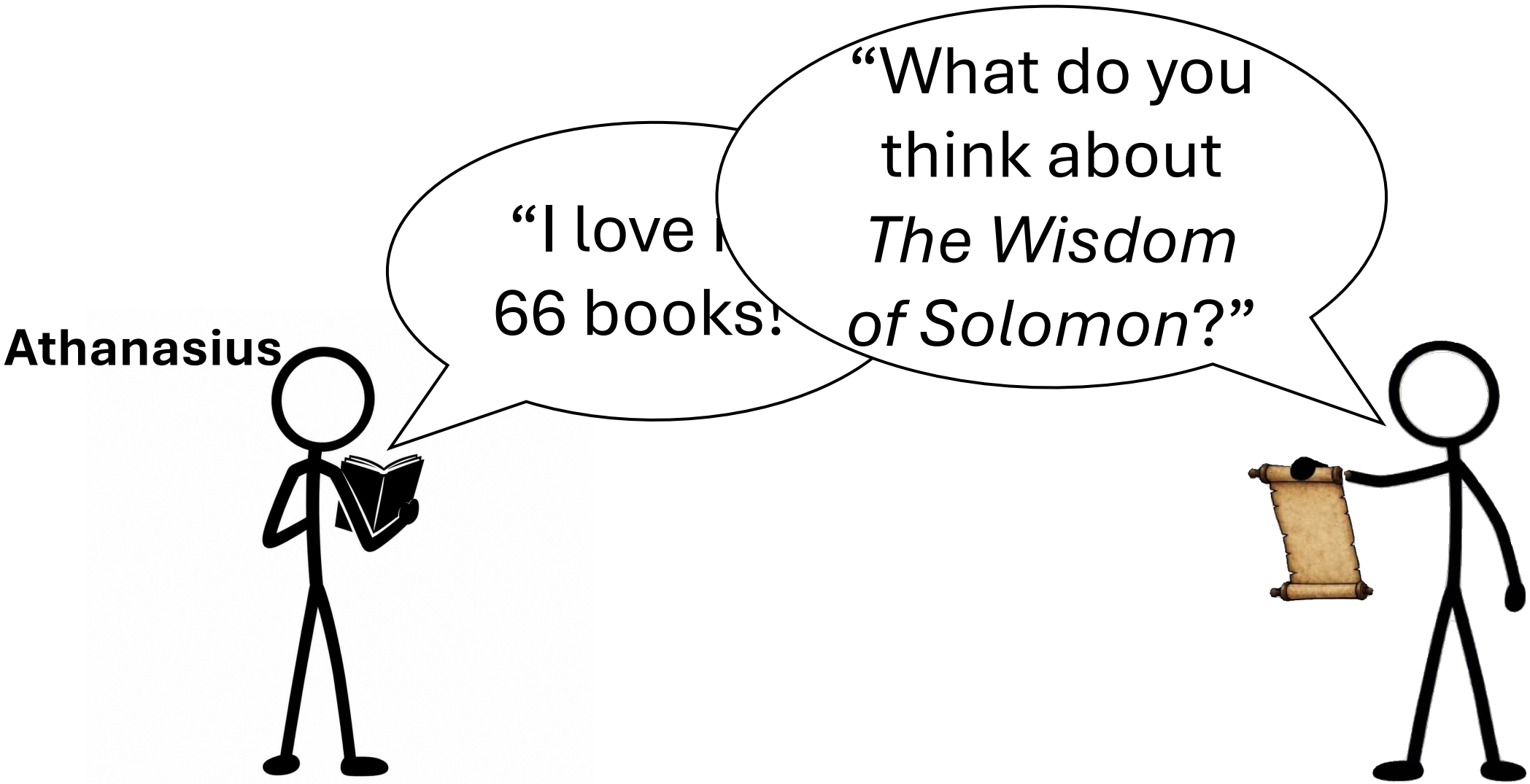
#3: “Authoritative, Sacred”

- “Authoritative” means something like: “Ought to be listened to”
- “Sacred” means: “holy,” “important,” etc.

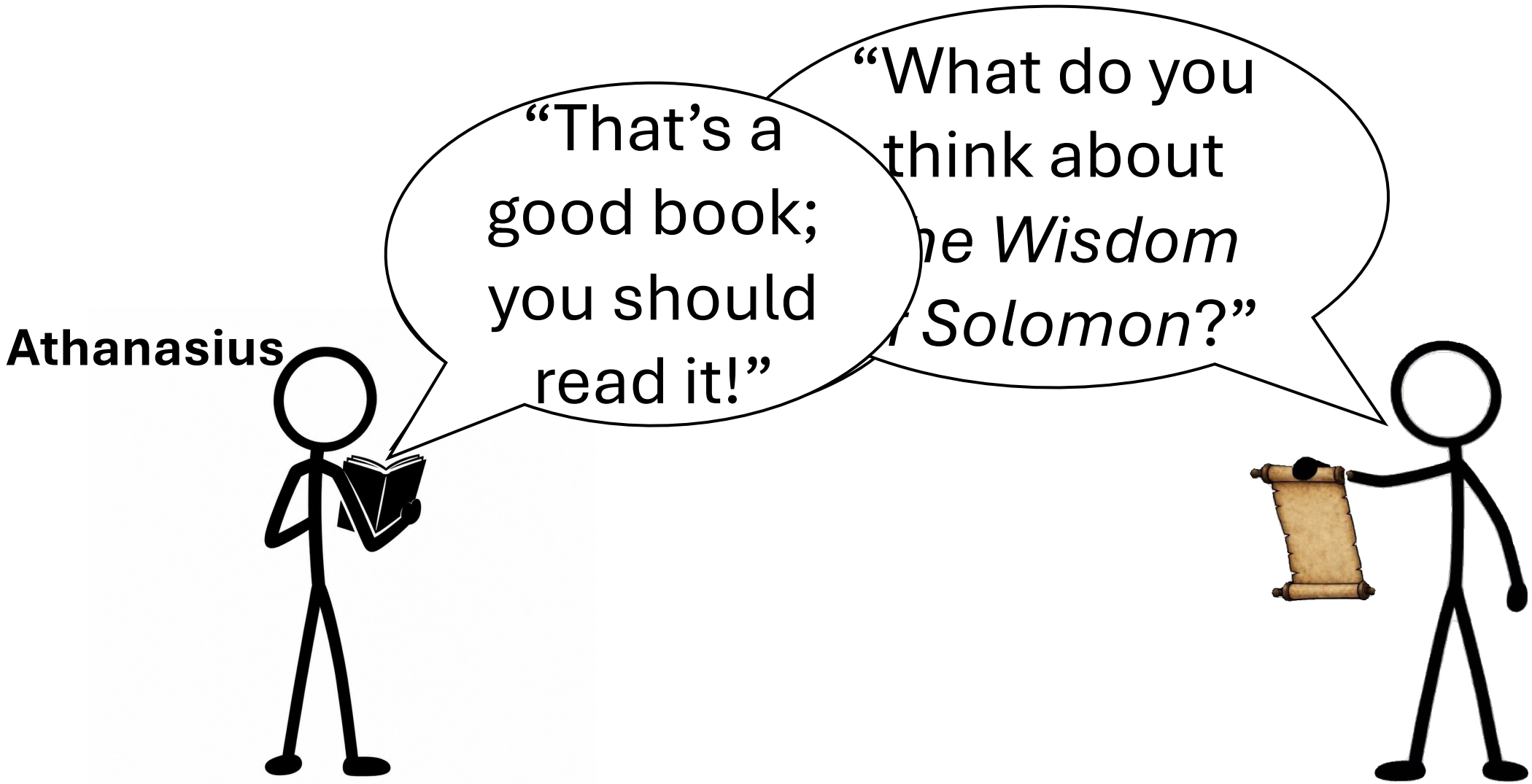
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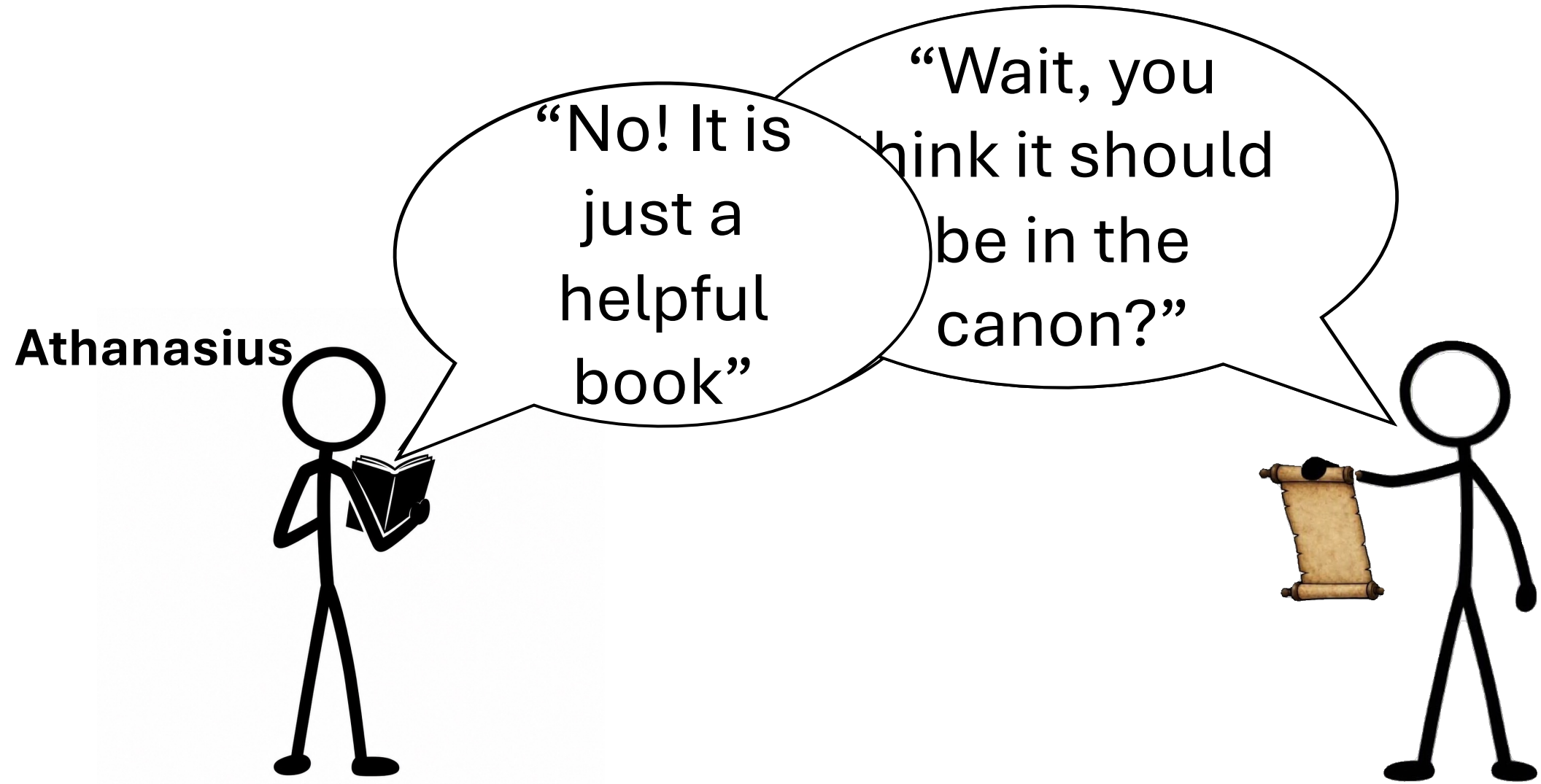


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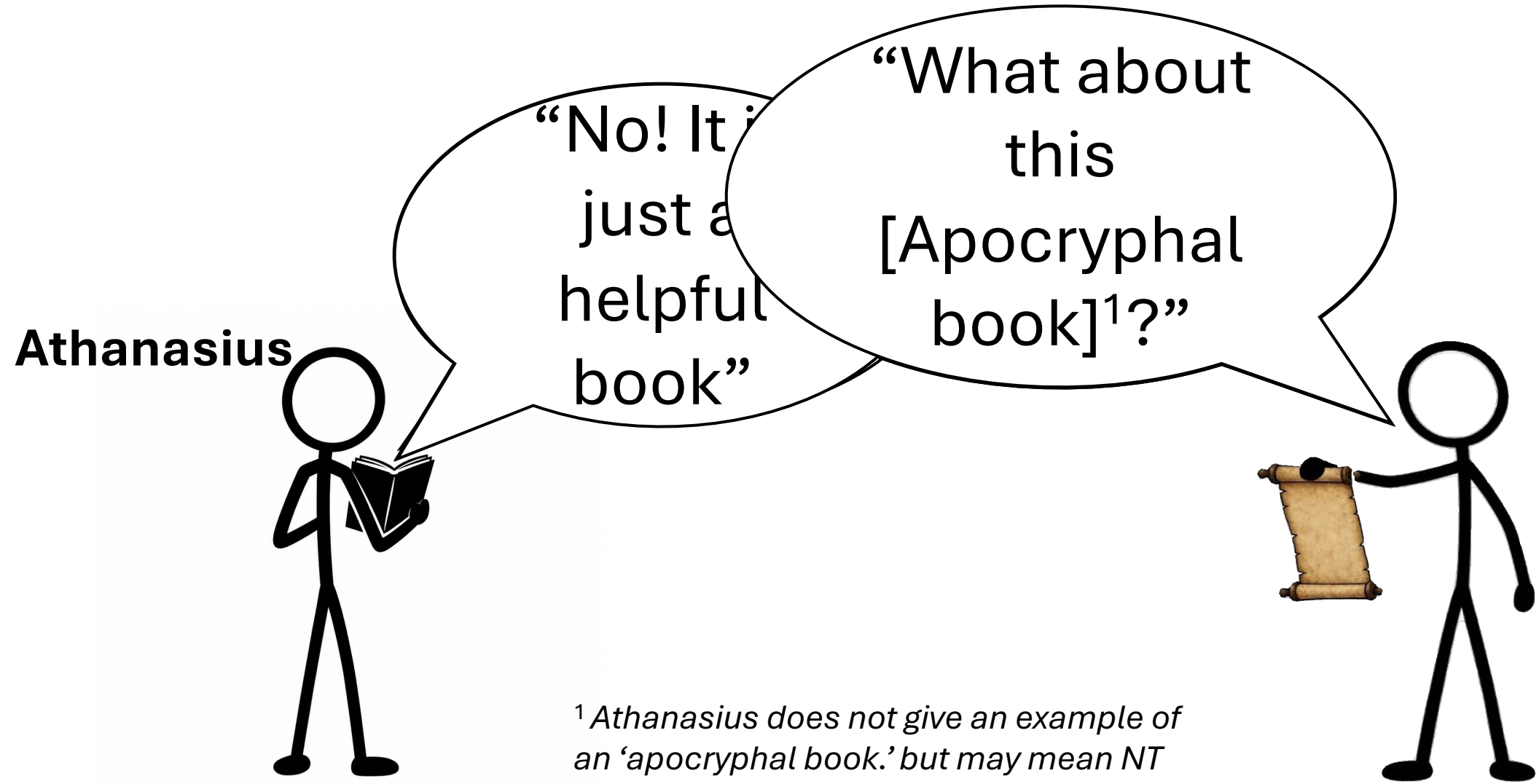


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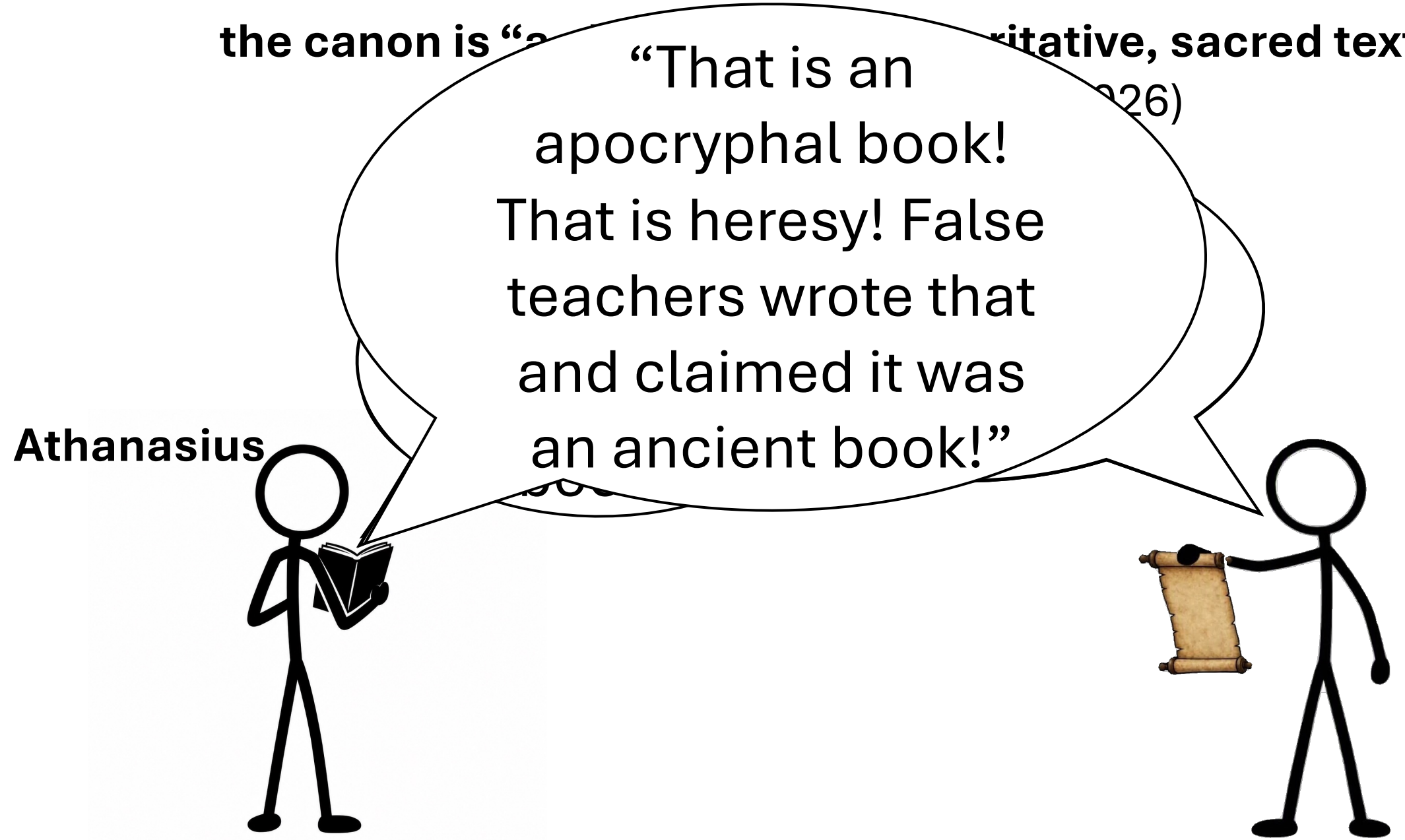


[1] *Athanasius does not give an example of an ‘apocryphal book.’ but may mean NT apocryphal like ‘Gospel of Thomas’*

the canon is “a … ritative, sacred texts”

…926)

Athanasius



Pushback to this Definition (by M. Kruger)

- Notes Sundberg's version: "the canon…[is] a final, fixed, closed list" (*Canon Revisited*, p. 35)
- Canon ≠ Scripture, the Canon is *made up of* "Scripture"
- "the strict demarcation between Scripture and canon may seem clear to Sundberg, it seems difficult to imagine these two concepts being separated within the minds of, say, second-century Christians. In order to recognize a certain book to be Scripture in the first place, an early Christian would have needed to be able to say another book in his library was *not* Scripture…. the term *Scripture* already implies exclusion and limitation to some degree, making a sharp distinction between Scripture and canon more difficult to sustain" (p. 36)

Pushback to this Definition (by M. Kruger)

- “before this time most of the New Testament books had already been functioning with sacred authority for generations, and their place in the New Testament corpus was fully secure. The supposed closing of the canon in the fourth century neither changed their status nor increased their authority—it was already as high as it could be. In regard to the function of these books, one could rightly say there was already a canon, or at least the category of a canon, well before the fourth century. Sundberg’s definition is so focused on the final stage of the canon’s development that it misses the fact that it is, after all, a *stage*—and therefore is intimately connected to, and dependent on, what has come before.... the concept of canon cannot be reduced to a single point of time. It is best conceived of as a continuum—less like a dot and more like a line” (p. 37)

Pushback to this Definition (by M. Kruger)

"from the perspective of God's revelational activity, a canon exists as soon as the New Testament books are written—the canon is always the books God has given to the corporate church, no more, no less" (p. 38)

Pushback to Kruger

- The question is, "*Which* books did God give us?"
- It is true that the books we should have in our canon are books "from God," but the ancient church debated on *which* books those were!
- We will not be abandoning the definition of "canon," but Kruger does give a good reminder that God had a part to play in the creation of the books

Misunderstanding “Scripture” in the NT

- 2 Timothy 3:16-17: “All Scripture” = OT Scripture, not “All the Bible” (NT canon not formed yet)

- 2 Peter 3:16 (c. 60AD-90AD) = Paul’s letters being equated with OT Scripture BUT STILL not “All the Bible” (NT canon not formed yet)

Class 2:
History of Canon Discussion (19th century)

Based on B. Metzger, *The Canon of the New Testament: Its Origin, Development, and Significance,* Oxford (1987)

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History of Canon Discussion

- Middle Ages: few quotes about the NT books
- Renaissance / Reformation: occasional questions about authorship of Hebrews, several of the Catholic Epistles, and Revelation, but “no one dared seriously to dispute their canonicity” (Metzger: p. 11)
- Luther: Hebrews, James, Jude, and Revelation are “inferior” but did not omit them from their translations of the NT (p. 11)
- Questions about the Canon arouse because of the Deistic movement

History of Canon Discussion



History of Canon Discussion

367 AD

Athanasius:
OT/NT

History of Canon Discussion

Renaissance and Reformation

Luther: “inferior” books, but
still includes in his NT

History of Canon Discussion

1698

John Toland

"He disputed the royal authorship of the *Eikon Basilike*…Toland took occasion to insinuate that, as people were mistaken on [the authorship of *Eikon Basilike*], so **they might be also about the authenticity of many of the early writings of Christianity**, including presumably books of the New Testament" (p. 12)

History of Canon Discussion

Jan 30, 1699

Reverend Offspring Blackall

- Preached a sermon before the House of Commons
- A chaplain of King William's "charged Toland with creating a scandal by what he had written" (p. 12)

History of Canon Discussion

1699

John Toland

Response: claimed that his earlier statements were only about the apocryphal writings, not the NT

“In the next breath, however, Toland raised questions that must, on the face of it, cast down on the validity of accepting as canonical several books of the New Testament” (p. 12)

1699

John Toland

“Thus he admitted that several spurious pieces are quoted by the Fathers as of equal authority with those that are generally received in the New Testament” (p. 12)

“He urged also that he could not understand why the writings of Mark and Luke should be accepted as canonical whereas those attributed to Clement of Rome and Barnabas are refused, since all four authors were equally companions and fellow-labourers with the apostles. In fact, Toland went so far as to declare, in so many words, that there is not one single book of the New Testament which was not refused by some of the ancient writers as being unjustly attributed to the apostles and as actually forged by their adversaries” (p. 12-13)

History of Canon Discussion

1699

John Toland

History of Canon Discussion

1700-1719

Samuel Clarke, Stephen Nye,
John Richardson, and others

- Strongly denounced Toland
- Richardson: “What the Apostles Wrote, and what they Authoriz’d, can be known in no other way, then by the Testimonies of those who liv’d at the same time with them, and the Tradition of those who succeeded them” (p. 13)

History of Canon Discussion

1726-1727

Jeremiah Jones

Used the “New and Full Method” of looking at ancient records to find early testimony or traditions of people concerning NT books written close to them in time

History of Canon Discussion

1726-1727

Jeremiah Jones

Jones made available for the first time an English translation of the text of dozens of apocryphal writings” (p. 14)

History of Canon Discussion

1699 (in France)

Jacques Basnage

Found that during the first 3 centuries “there was no decision concerning the limits of the New Testament canon, but each local church had the liberty to choose or reject individual books; this freedom was most noticeable among Eastern Churches in rejecting the Apocalypse” (p. 16)

History of Canon Discussion

1804-1812

J. G. Eichhorn

“The first to attribute to Marcion the stimulus to collect the New Testament writings, and argued that the core of the future canon was established by about AD 175” (p. 18)

History of Canon Discussion

1826

W. M. L. De Wette

“Extended the history of the gradual development of the canon up to the year 400” (p. 18)

History of Canon Discussion

1826 (in America)

Archibald Alexander

- Wrote the first book (in the US) dealing solely with the Biblical canon
- "Argued that **<u>the criterion of New Testament canonicity is apostolic authorship</u>**, whether direct or indirect (the latter in the case of Mark and Luke). Apostolicity is to be established by historically verified testimonies of patristic writers of the early Christian centuries" (p. 18)

History of Canon Discussion

1866

Constantin von Tischendorf

Argued the canon of the NT was established by the beginning of the 2nd century

History of Canon Discussion

1855 (in Britian)

Brooke Foss Westcott

Said that the formulation of the canon was one of “the first instinctive acts of the Christian society, resting upon the general confession of the Churches and not upon independent opinions of its members” (p. 21)

History of Canon Discussion

1874-1877

Walter R. Cassels

Wrote an anonymous work in three volumes which revived some of the old arguments of 18th century Deism. His “purpose was to show from patristic testimony that the canonical Gospels are so far removed in time from the events they record that they lose all competence as witnesses to the reality of the miraculous” (p. 22)

History of Canon Discussion

1894

Adolf Jülicher

“Said that the public reading…of Christian books and epistles in a liturgical setting, along with Old Testament books already regarded as authoritative, that was chiefly responsible for their being recognized eventually as canonical Scripture” (p. 23)

History of Canon Discussion

1888-1901

Theodor Zahn

Believed the canon “came into existence by the end of the first century” (p. 23-24)

History of Canon Discussion

1889

Adolf Harnack

- Chief rival against Zahn
- Said that the canon was one of the three barriers which the Church created to defend against heresies such as Gnosticism (the other two were the creed and the bishopric)
- The process was a “competition” of books and the most helpful survived

History of Canon Discussion

1888-1901

Theodor Zahn

“Understood [the canon] as a collection of books possessing authority, but he did not insist that this authority should be based on the thesis that ‘the New Testament is holy Scripture’” (p. 24)

1889

Adolf Harnack

History of Canon Discussion

1888-1901

Theodor Zahn

"He was satisfied if, for instance, the four Gospels are an authority because of the authority of the Lord's sayings which they contain. He could…speak of the existence of a NT 'canon' [at the close of the 1st century]" (p. 24)

1889

Adolf Harnack

"New Testament canon is a collection of books that possessed authority *because* they were regarded as holy Scripture. Accordingly he placed the rise of the New Testament canon at the close of the 2nd century" (p. 24)

Class 3:
History of Canon Discussion (20th century)

Based on B. Metzger, *The Canon of the New Testament: Its Origin, Development, and Significance,* Oxford (1987)

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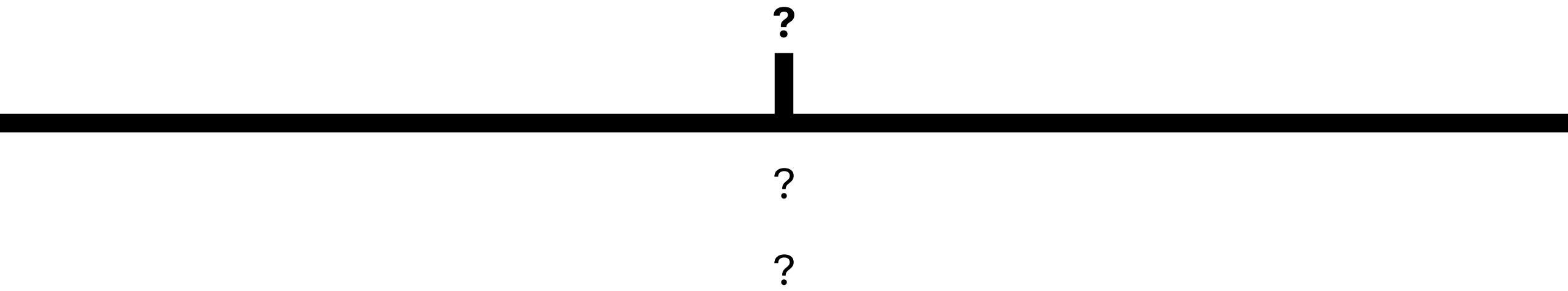
History of Canon Discussion

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- The process was a “competition” of books and the most helpful survived

History of Canon Discussion



Class 4:
Modern Canonical Models

Based on M. Kruger, *Canon Revisited: Establishing the Origins and Authority of the New Testament Books*, Crossway (2012)

Download Slides

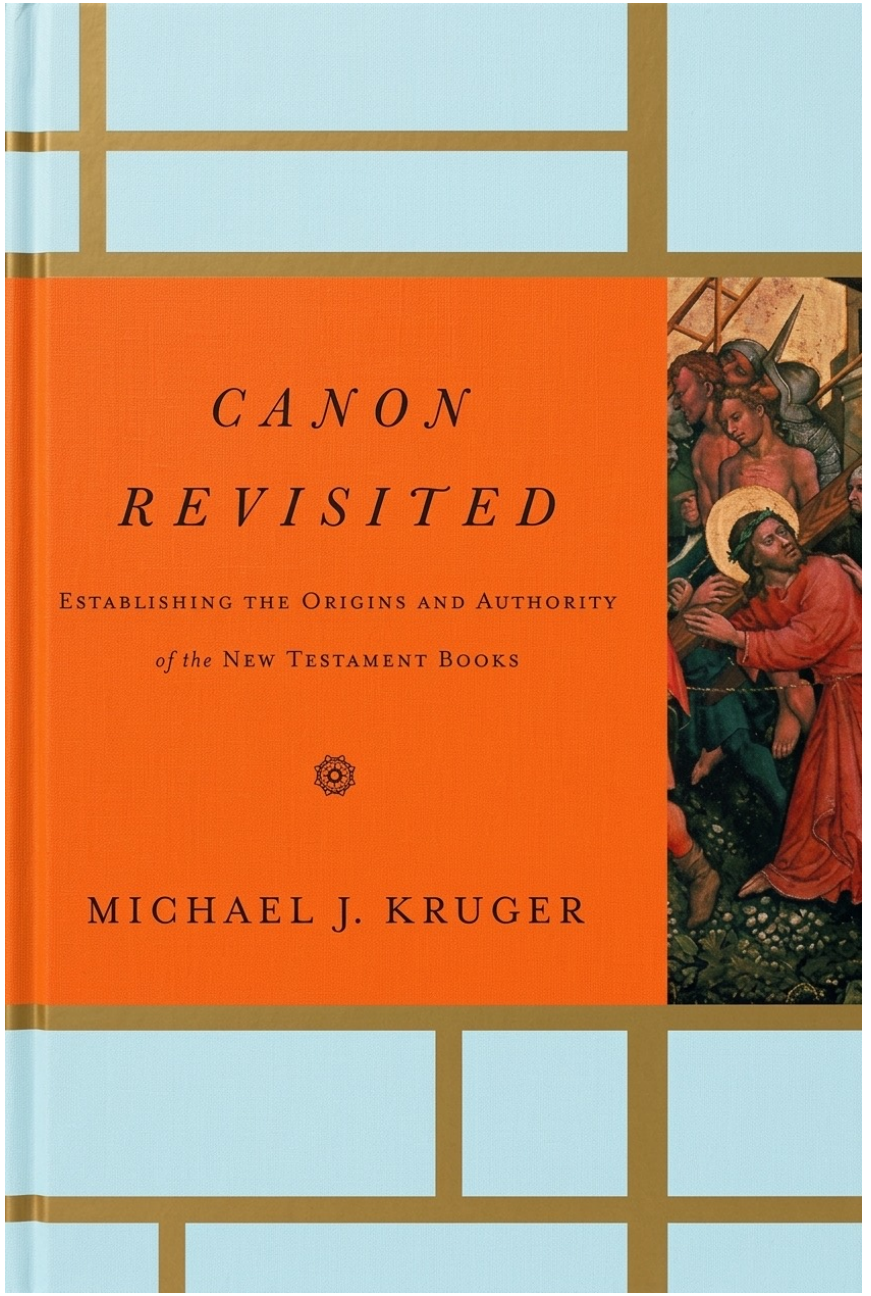
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Sources

- *Canon Revisited* by Michael J. Kruger

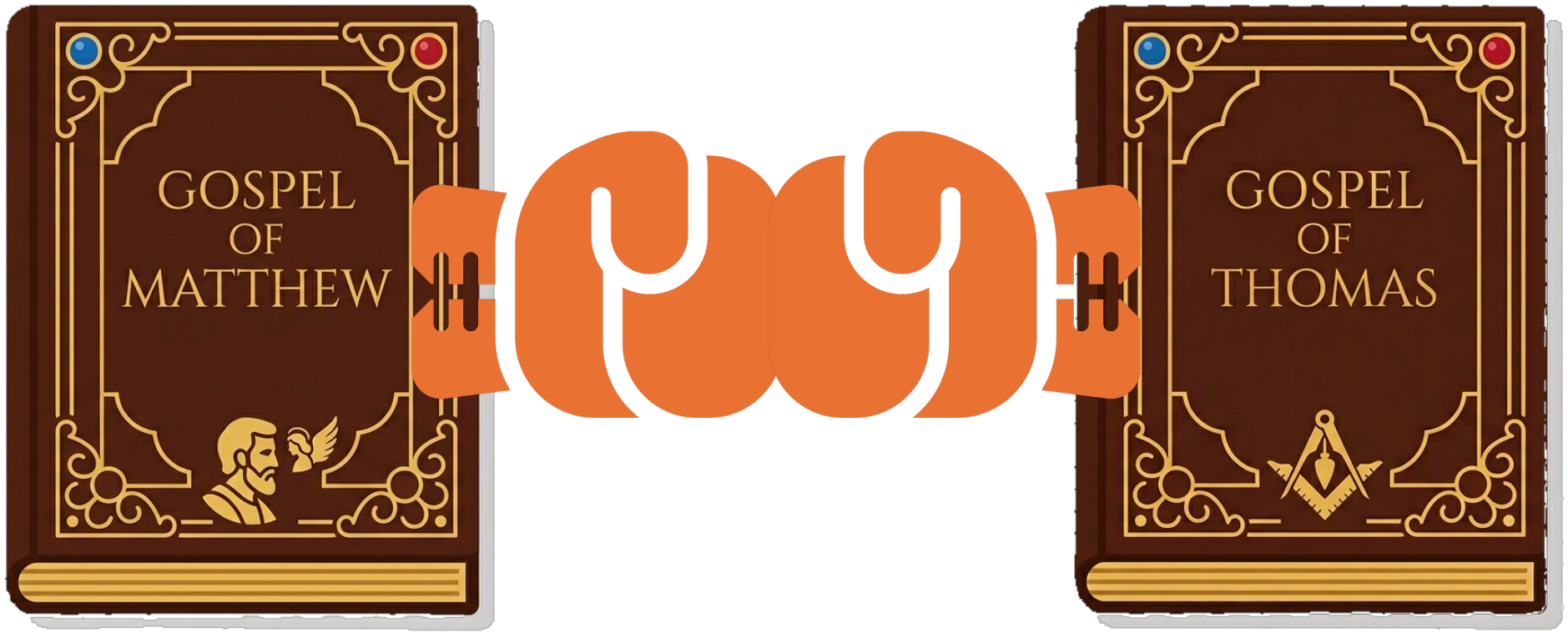
- Canon discussed for a Christian audience, not for debating skeptics
  - “Nor, as we discussed in the introduction, are we attempting to somehow “prove” to the skeptic (in a way that would satisfy him) that these books are indeed from God. Rather, the question before us is whether the Christian faith, with its twenty-seven-book New Testament, can give an adequate account for how it can be known that these books are canonical” (p. 92)



Historical-Critical Model

- “Scholars have argued that the idea of a canon, with its particular boundaries, is simply (or largely) the product of human activities within the church during the early centuries of Christianity” (p. 30)
- “Thus, canon is just a social phenomenon that arises when a community desires to express its identity” (p. 31)
- “Bauer argues that there was no “orthodoxy” or “heresy” within earliest Christianity, but rather there were various “Christianities,” each competing for dominance. Thus, says Bauer, the New Testament canon we possess is nothing more than the books chosen by the eventual theological winners—a historical accident, so to speak” (p. 32)

Historical-Critical Model



Historical-Critical Method



Historical-Critical Model Evaluation

- “the historical-critical model is correct to remind us of the role of the Christian community in the formation of the New Testament canon…. That being said, however, the fundamental problem with the historical-critical model is not its affirmation that the church played a role, but rather its insistence that the church played the determinative and decisive role. Quickly swept aside are any claims that these books contain any intrinsic authority that might have been a factor in their reception” (pp. 34-35)

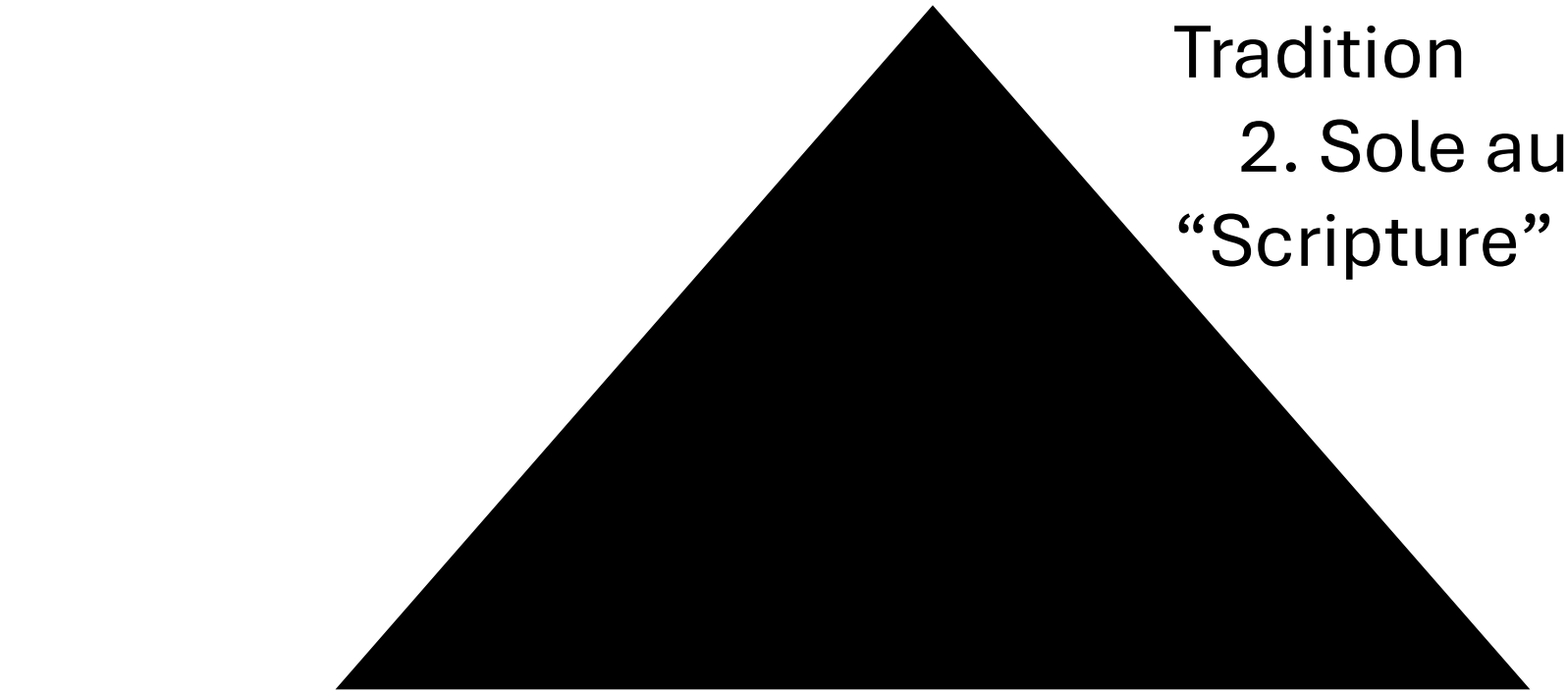
- “simply demonstrating some human involvement in the canonical process is not sufficient to demonstrate *sole* human involvement. The fact that proximate, human decisions played a role in the development of the canon does not rule out the possibility that ultimate, divine activity also played a role. The two are not mutually exclusive” (p. 35)

1. Historical-Critical Model = Boxing Match
2. Roman Catholic Model

Roman Catholic Model

- “At the core of the Roman Catholic view of canon is Rome’s view of the authority of Scripture. Roman Catholicism denies that ultimate authority exists in the Scriptures alone (*sola scriptura*) and has consequently adopted the well-known trifold authority structure that includes Scripture, tradition, and the Magisterium (the church’s teaching authority)” (pp. 38–39)

Roman Catholic Model



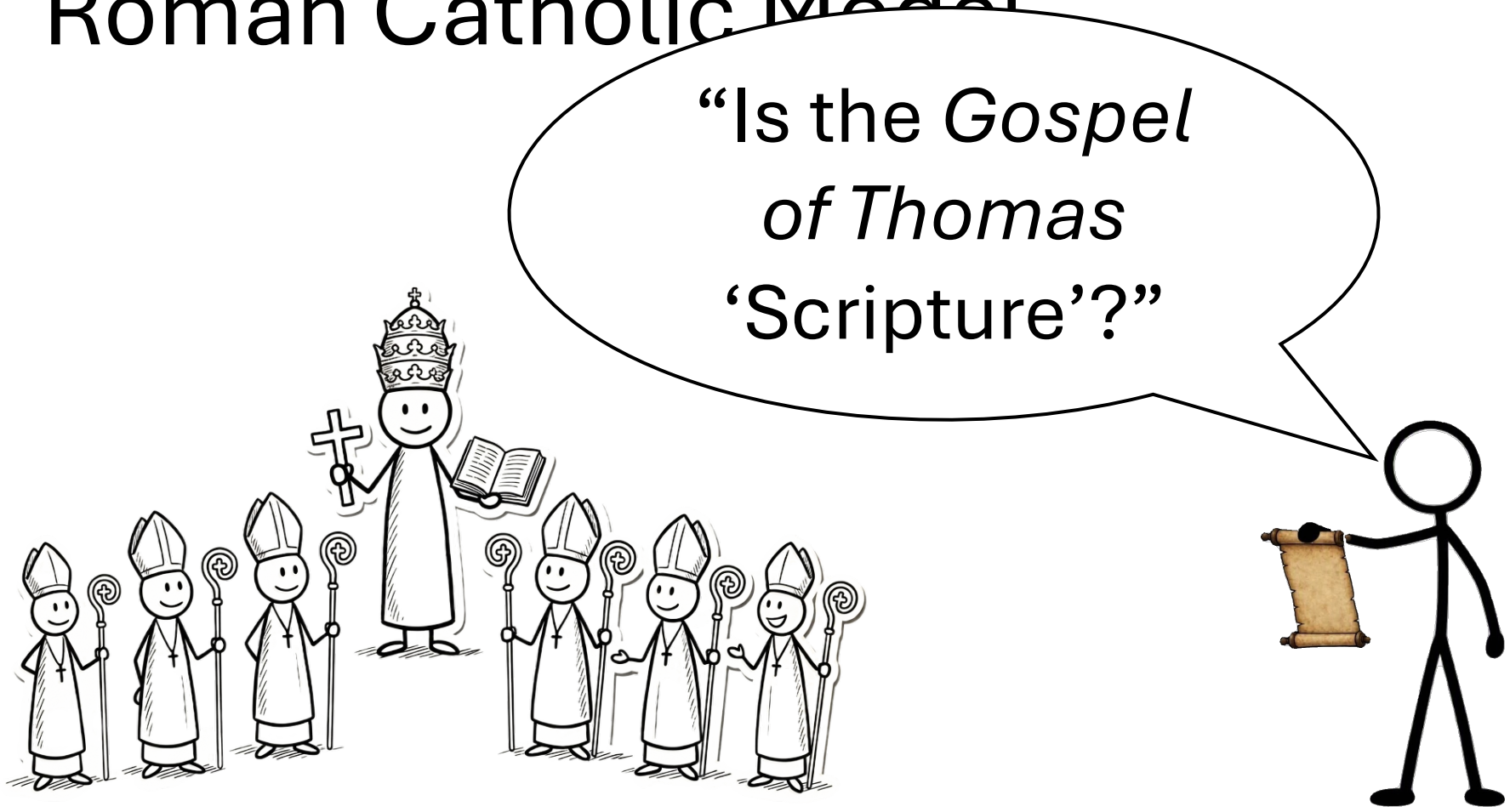
= 1. Interprets Scripture and Tradition

2. Sole authority to define "Scripture" and "Tradition"

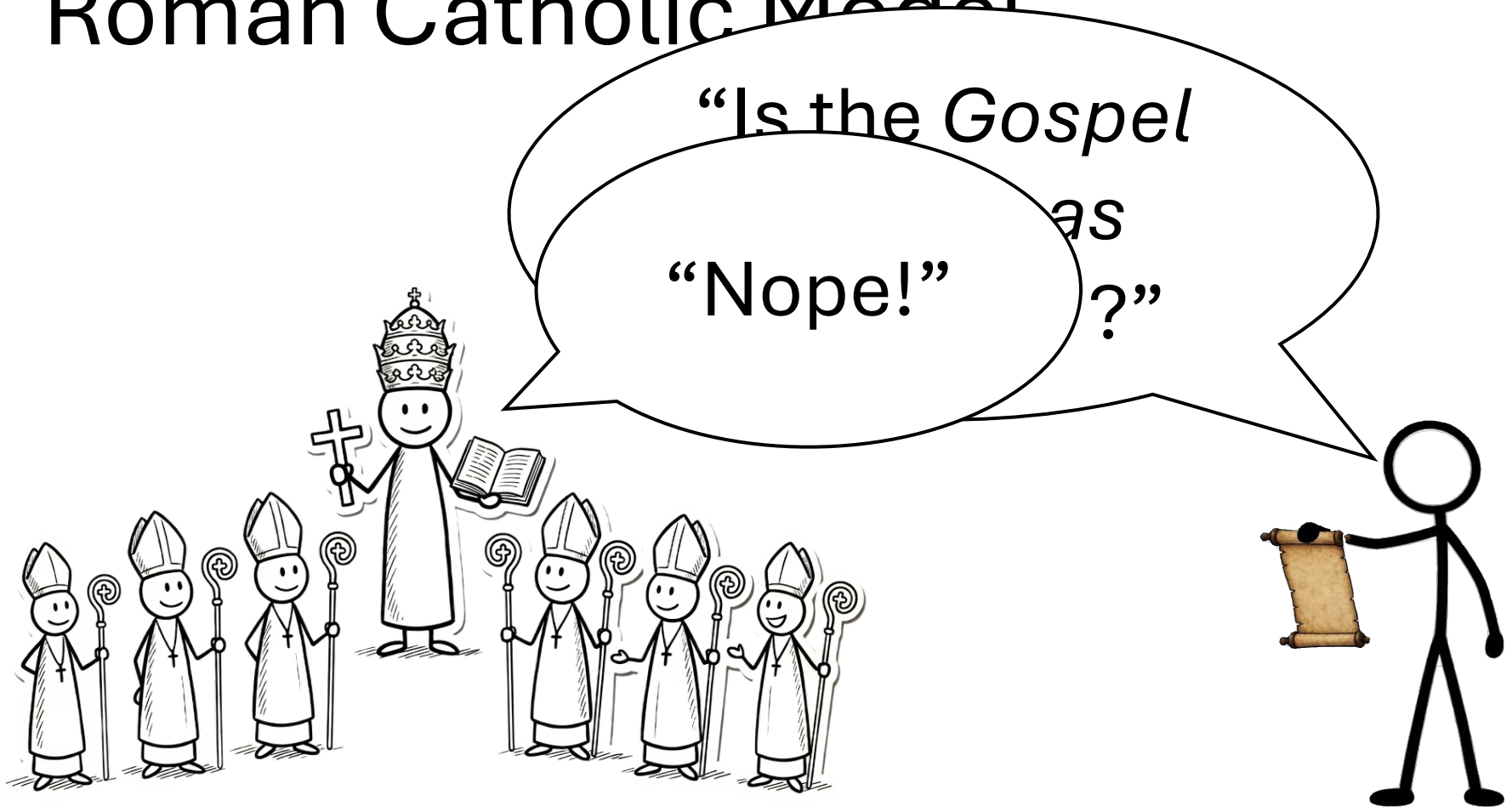
Roman Catholic Model



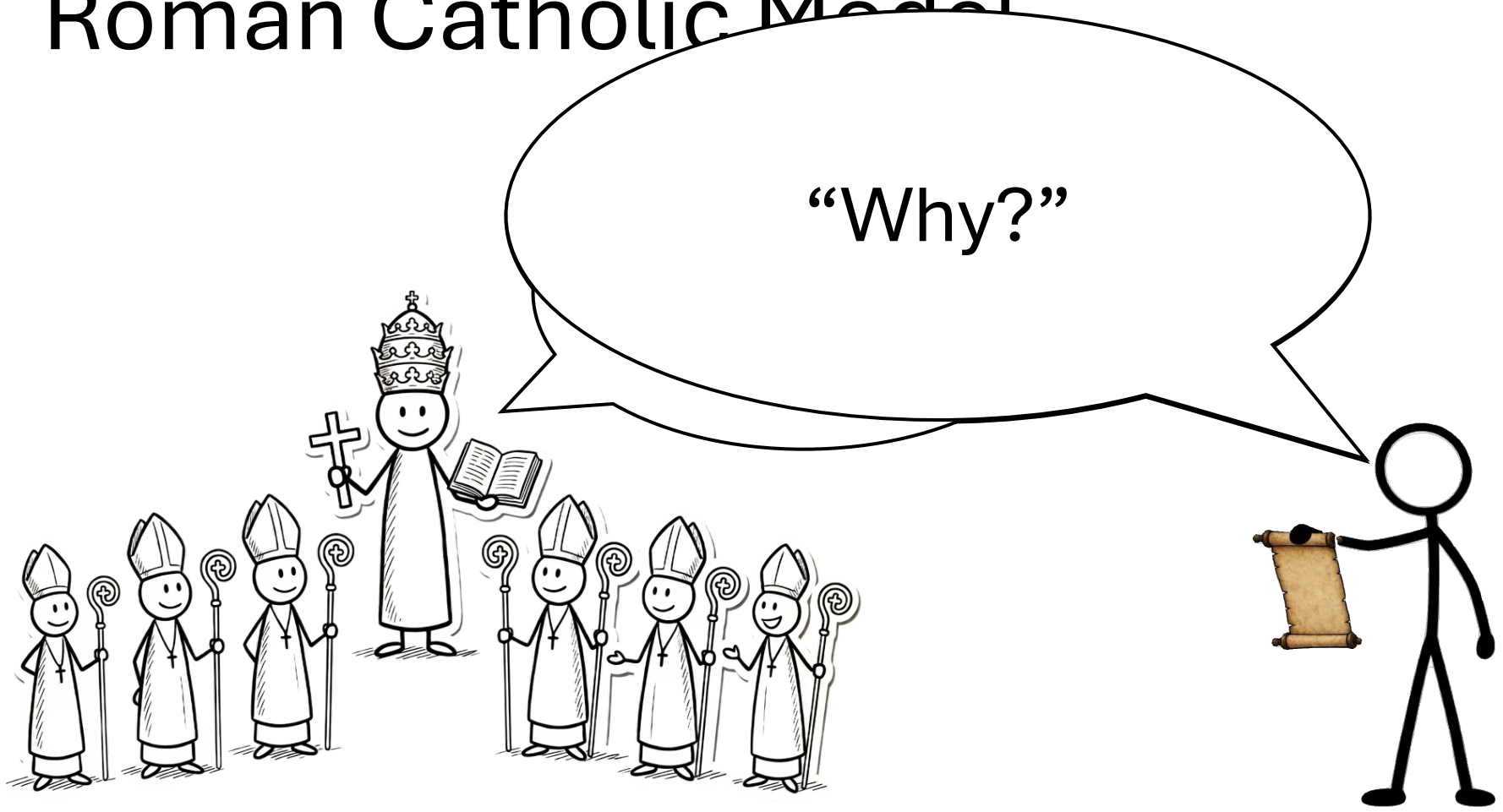
Roman Catholic Model



Roman Catholic Model



Roman Catholic Model



Roman Catholic Model



Roman Catholic Model

- “H. J. Adriaanse observes, ‘Catholic Theology … has solved the canon problem with a plea to the authority of the Church’” (p. 39)
- “Thus, the canon is ultimately community determined. The fundamental challenge from Roman Catholicism is that in order to have an infallible Scripture, we need to have an infallible guide (namely, the church) to tell us what is, and what is not, Scripture” (pp. 39–40)
- “Karl Rahner asserts, ‘[Scripture] exists because the church exists’” (p. 40)
- “the term *canon* is often used simply to refer to the books that functioned as an authoritative ‘norm’ or standard for the Christian community, that is, as Scripture” (p. 40)
- Belief the NT books are inspired and ”Thus, Joseph Lienhard… [declares] that ‘about 180 [AD], there is a New Testament’ and ‘a New Testament exists when a collection of Christian writings is generally accepted in the church as equal in authority to the Jewish Scriptures” (p. 40)

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

- Different conceptions in this model:

1. "The church not as creating or constituting the canon, but merely as recognizing the authority of the canon that was already there" (p. 41)
   - "The church's role is primarily epistemological—it is the sole and fundamental means by which we infallibly *know* which books belong in the canon" (p. 41)
   - "The Bible is in the Church, but *not from the Church*" (Lienhard as qtd on p. 41)
2. "The church not simply as the means by which the canon is infallibly recognized (although it does affirm this), but as, in some sense, the foundation or the grounds for the canon" (p. 42)
   - "We 'derive the essence of the Scripture from the essence of the church' and therefore the Scripture is 'derivative' from the church and 'an act of the Church'" (Rahner as qtd on p. 42)
   - "Peter Kreeft…argues that the church 'caused' the canon because it preceded the canon" (p. 42)
   - "Hans Küng…: 'Without the Church there would be no New Testament" (p. 42)

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

1. “The church not as creating or constituting the canon, but merely as recognizing the authority of the canon that was already there” (p. 41)
   - Claims that without the RCC, there is *no way of knowing* which books belong in the canon
   - “If only Christians had…[an] inspired table of contents, then we would not need the authoritative rulings of the Roman Catholic Church to authenticate the canon” (p. 42)
- The issue here:
   - How does one know that this “inspired table of contents” is really inspired? Wouldn’t the RCC need to confirm that too!

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

1. “The church not as creating or constituting the canon, but merely as recognizing the authority of the canon that was already there” (p. 41)
   - “The problem, then, is not that the church plays a role in identifying canonical books (Protestants would agree with this), but the Catholic insistence that it plays the *only* and *definitive* role” (p. 44)

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

2. “The church not simply as the means by which the canon is infallibly recognized (although it does affirm this), but as, in some sense, the foundation or the grounds for the canon” (p. 42)
   - But the apostolic teachings are the foundation of the church, not the other way around (cf. Eph 2:20)!
   - Chapman: “The biblical canon is not a creation of the church, the church is instead a creation of the biblical canon” (qtd on p. 44)
   - Paul’s writings were authoritative before the RCC! (cf. 1 Thess 2:13, Gal 1:1-24, 2 Peter 3:16)
   - The Council of Trent (1546) was the RCC’s official declaration of the canon. No canon before that?

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

2. “The church not simply as the means by which the canon is infallibly recognized (although it does affirm this), but as, in some sense, the foundation or the grounds for the canon” (p. 42)
    - J. I. Parker: “The Church no more gave us the New Testament canon than Sir Isaac Newton gave us the force of gravity. God gave us gravity … Newton did not create gravity but recognized it” (qtd on p. 45)

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

- The problem with RCM: confuses the instruments God used to produce the Bible (humans) and God's work to make the canon
- The NT canon is not the production of the church but of God, recognized by the church

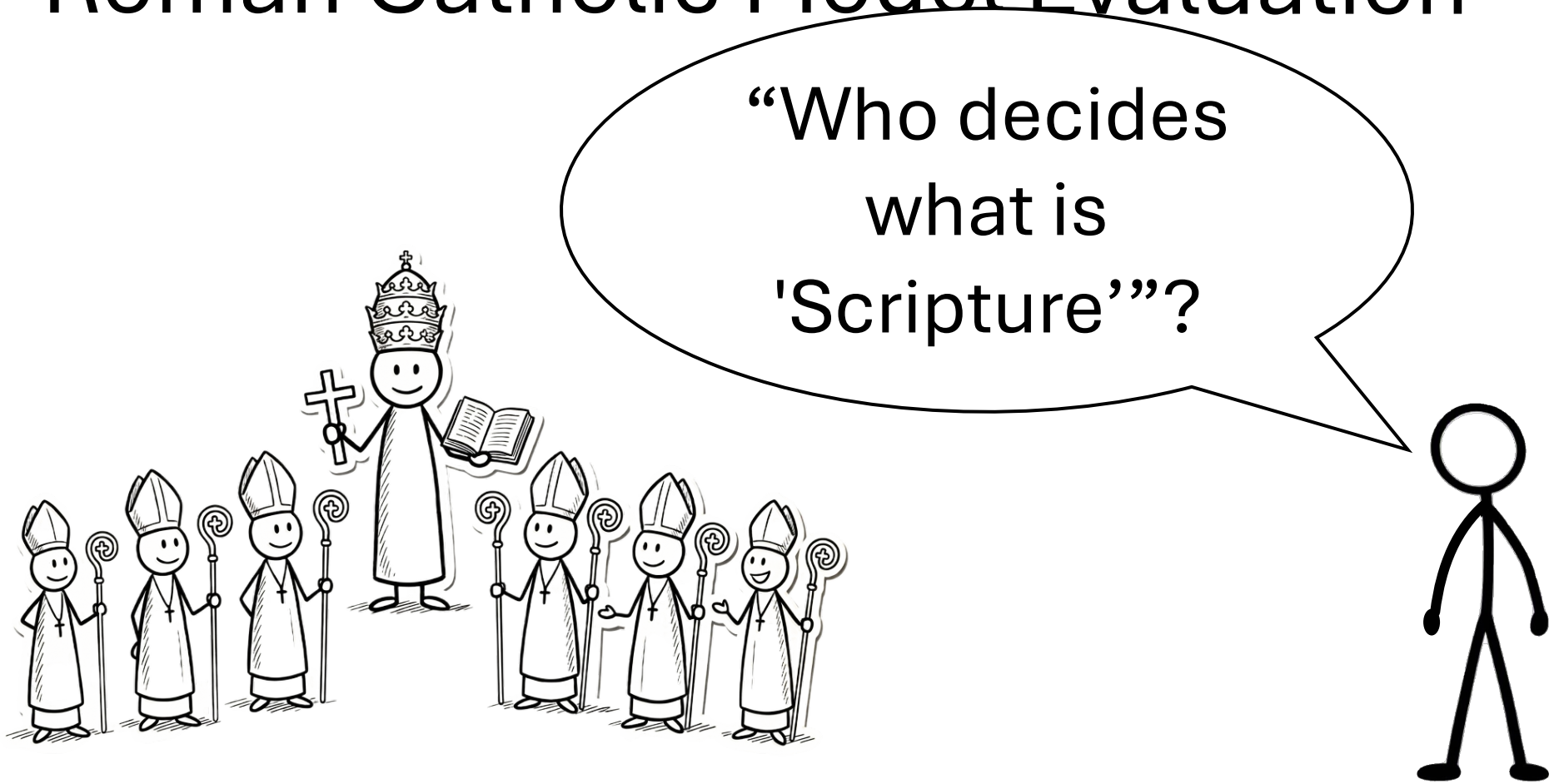
Roman Catholic Model Evaluation

- Where does RCC get its authority from?
  1. From the Scriptures? That is circular reasoning!
  2. From history? But those aren't *infallible* grounds
  3. Only logical answer: "the church's authority is self-authenticating and needs no external authority to validate it" (p. 47)

Roman Catholic Model Evaluation



Roman Catholic Model Evaluation



Roman Catholic Model Evaluation



Roman Catholic Model Evaluation



Roman Catholic Model Evaluation



1. Historical-Critical Model = Boxing Match
2. Roman Catholic Model

1. Historical-Critical Model = Boxing Match
2. Roman Catholic Model = Church Created
3. Canonical-Critical Model